Going on a journey: A review of the customer journey literature

Customer journey has become an increasingly important concept to understand complex customer behaviours and get insights into their experiences. While the term has been used in diverse disciplines since the 1990s and its literature has grown more than sevenfold over the last eight years, understanding of the topic remains incoherent. This paper adopted a stream-based systematic review approach to identify the underlying themes of the customer journey presented in the business literature up to May 2020. 147 relevant papers were retrieved from Scopus, Web of Science and EBSCO for the analysis. The quantitative content analysis identified five underlying themes of the customer journey, namely, service satisfaction, failure and recovery, co-creation, customer response, channels and technological disruption. The results section reviewed and discussed each theme and its sub-themes in turn. The review identified important gaps in the literature related to the key stages of a customer journey.

Keywords: Customer journey; service satisfaction, failure, and recovery; co-creation; customer response

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1. Introduction

In the past few years, the concept of customer journey has been widely adopted by both academics and practitioners. Such interest has been driven by the emerging prominence of the customer-centric philosophy in the marketing field (Crosier & Handford, 2012). The term customer journey commonly refers to a process or sequence that a customer goes through to access or use an offering of a company (Følstad & Kvale, 2018b). Using customer journeys as the driver of business operations differs from traditional approaches, such as service blueprinting, which focus on the corporate perspective and neglect the customer view (Bolton, Gustafsson, McColl-Kennedy, Sirianni, & Tse, 2014). The concept places customers at its heart, making it a useful framework in assessing and evaluating customer experience within any service context (Mangiaracina, Brugnoli, & Perego, 2009). The analysis of customer journeys is useful in highlighting critical service moments and touchpoints that are significant for the formation of customer experience (Rawson, Duncan, & Jones, 2013). The recognition of the customer journey as a means to enhance and manage customer experience has driven the recent growth of the customer journey literature.

Attempts have been made to review the historical roots, terminologies and approaches of the customer journey based on 45 articles published prior to 2013 (Følstad & Kvale, 2018b). However, the literature has evolved quickly, covering a wide range of themes and areas, evidenced by a diverse set of related marketing aspects and divergent uses of customer journeys in empirical studies (Åkesson, Edvardsson, & Tronvoll, 2014; Canfield & Basso, 2017; Chen, Kyaw, & Ross, 2008; Fornari, Fornari, Grandi, Menegatti, & Hofacker, 2016; Klaus, 2013; Lim, Al-Aali, & Heinrichs, 2015; Muskat, Muskat, Zehrer, & Johns, 2013; Panzera et al., 2017). Hence, past literature on customer journey does not appear coherent. Given that the

customer journey literature has grown more than sevenfold in the past eight years and the previous review (Følstad & Kvale, 2018b) focused on the terminology as well as its applications in service design, there is a need to revisit this fast-growing body of work and examine the underlying themes to integrate the understanding of the customer journey into other constructs in business and marketing studies.

This paper takes a customer journey perspective to develop a systematic understanding of the customer journey by identifying the underlying themes of the phenomenon, placing them in context and synthesising the current body of knowledge. The attempt to aggregate and integrate the relevant literature to date provides a theoretical groundwork for future development of the topic.

The analysis is organised into seven sections. The next part discusses the methodology employed for the review. Section three summaries a profile of the customer journey literature. Section four presents the quantitative content analysis. Section five discusses the five themes of the customer journey in detail. The results sections do not include a comprehensive discussion on the terminology and historical background of the customer journey as this has already been undertaken in the review by Følstad and Kvale (2018b). Readers may refer to that review for detailed discussions of the subjects. Section six proposes potential future research avenues in the area of customer journeys. The last section presents the conclusion and discusses the limitations of the review.

2. Methodology

Systematic review papers can be of several types (Paul & Criado, 2020; Snyder, 2019), namely, Structured review focusing on widely used methods, theories and constructs (Canabal & White III, 2008; Kahiya, 2018; Mishra, Singh, & Koles, 2020; Paul & Singh, 2017; Rosado-Serrano, Paul, & Dikova, 2018), Stream-based review identifying research themes (Jones, Coviello, &

Tang, 2011; Prayag & Ozanne, 2018; Schmitt, Raisch, & Volberda, 2018; Vahidzadeh, Bertanza, Sbaffoni, & Vaccari, 2020), Bibliometric review analysing citations and co-citations (Donthu, Kumar, & Pattnaik, 2020; Goyal & Kumar, 2020; Randhawa, Wilden, & Hohberger, 2016), Framework-based review using a framework to integrate the existing knowledge (Paul & Benito, 2018; Xie, Reddy, & Liang, 2017), Hybrid- Narrative review providing a framework for setting future research agenda (Bahoo, Alon, & Paltrinieri, 2020; Dabić et al., 2020; Kumar, Paul, & Unnithan, 2020; Paul, Parthasarathy, & Gupta, 2017), Theory-based review discussing the role of a specific theory (Gilal, Zhang, Paul, & Gilal, 2019; Paul & Rosado-Serrano, 2019), Meta-analysis synthesising results of empirical works (Barari, Ross, Thaichon, & Surachartkumtonkun, 2020; Knoll & Matthes, 2017; Rana & Paul, 2020) and reviews aiming for model or theory development (Paul, 2019; Paul & Mas, 2019). This review was conducted as a stream-based systematic review to produce robust and reliable results that synthesise and map the knowledge related to the customer journey. The approach was suitable as the customer journey has been conceptualised differently and studied in relation to diverse concepts in the business discipline (Wong, Greenhalgh, Westhorp, Buckingham, & Pawson, 2013).

The process of the review adopted the steps guided by Tranfield, Denyer, and Smart (2003). A PRISMA diagram (Moher, Liberati, Tetzlaff, Altman, & The PRISMA Group, 2009) (Figure 1) has been produced to summarise the flow of information included in this review. The preliminary stage involved a discussion among the three members of the review team to set the research protocol. A precise guideline was produced to facilitate the transparency and the objectivity of the review. The SPICE framework (Booth, 2004) was applied to formulate a review question and facilitate the decision of the inclusion and exclusion criteria at this stage. The question is, from the perspective of the customer journey, what are the relevant business and marketing concepts that have been studied in the customer journey literature published in academic journals prior to May 2020. The initial set of search keywords was *"customer*

journey" or "consumer journey". However, this limited search excluded some key papers, due to the lack of a universal definition and the cross-disciplinary perspectives of the term (Følstad & Kvale, 2018b). Therefore, *"touchpoint" or "touch point"*, which was recognised as a building block of customer journeys (Clatworthy, 2011), was employed as an additional search string. The systematic review on the terminologies of the customer journey by Følstad and Kvale (2018b) also revealed that the concept of touchpoints was, explicitly or implicitly, discussed in all articles about the customer journey. Therefore, the selected terms were utilised to locate as many relevant publications as possible (Schibrowsky, Peltier, & Nill, 2007).

INSERT FIGURE 1

The search was conducted within three electronic databases, namely Scopus, Business Source Complete in EBSCO and Web of Science to ensure a comprehensive coverage of the relevant literature (Lu, Papagiannidis, & Alamanos, 2018; Martín-Martín, Orduna-Malea, Thelwall, & López-Cózar, 2018). The analysis covered approximately twenty years of research on the customer journey, up until May 2020. After removing duplicates, the search yielded a total of 401 studies, 208 and 193 from 'customer journey' and 'touchpoint', respectively. The abstract of each retrieved study was extracted to a spreadsheet for the review panel to assess their relevance. For an article to be included, it had to be related to business and marketing, written in English and available in full text. The exclusion criteria were also set for quality appraisal. Articles not related to customer journeys or focused on either customer behaviour or a specific touchpoint, but not related to a customer journey context, were excluded. Non-academic and non-published studies were also excluded to represent only validated academic knowledge and to avoid heterogeneity issues in the analysis (Denyer & Tranfield, 2009; Salipante, Notz, & Bigelow, 1982). The three panel members reviewed the extracted information independently to reduce the risk of biased decisions (Hasson, Keeney, & McKenna, 2000; Paul & Singh,

2017). Only documents that found agreement from at least two out of three members were incorporated and analysed. The final set of retrieved papers comprised 147 documents, 103 and 44 from 'customer journey' and 'touchpoint', respectively.

A cluster-based feature selection and document classification was adopted as an analysis procedure of the study (Chaussabel & Sher, 2002; Yeh, Jen, & Hsu, 2012). Document classification is a supervised text mining technique to group similar documents together according to a set of pre-defined categories (Zhai & Massung, 2016). However, the literature retrieved from the online databases was unlabelled for the purposes of the systematic review. Therefore, term clustering was first utilised to identify the embedded themes and common keywords discussed in the review articles, and they were thus labelled. The quantitative content analysis deduced statistically significant concepts and themes in the text corpus, thus increasing the replicability, objectivity and generalisability of the research findings (Randhawa et al., 2016; Riffe, Lacy, & Fico, 2014). QDA Miner, a textual analysis software program, with its quantitative extension WordStat, were used for the process, based on a dictionary construction approach.

Words that appear in either every case or rare cases had low discriminative value for text classification (Yeh et al., 2012). Therefore, the cut-off thresholds were set to remove terms occurring less than 4 or more than 70% of the cases from the dictionary. In addition, methodology terms were also discarded because they were not meaningful in identifying the embedded themes of the articles. The quantitative content analysis software produced the universal meaning of each word by approximating their connotations in the text corpus. However, words were only meaningful within their specific context. Thus, common phrase extraction and keyword-in-context were performed to reduce semantic ambiguity, false positive and false negative errors, and to validate the dictionary (Péladeau & Stovall, 2005).

Lastly, for the dictionary construction phase, words with similar meanings or words that shared the same ideas were grouped and decoded as synonyms of a single word entry (Yeh et al., 2012).

Cluster analysis was employed as a tool for thematic identification and feature reduction. The content analysis software computed the Jaccard similarity and the co-occurrences between words (Péladeau & Stovall, 2005), in the same and different cases, to produce a dendrogram representing the result of the clustering process. Terms with high similarities were put in the same cluster, with lesser associates in the neighbouring branches. The major clusters that contained four or more terms were extracted as categorisation indexes and features of the articles. As a result, five clusters and their branches were identified and labelled as themes and sub-themes of the literature. The embedded themes of a text could be discovered by the semantic patterns or the repetition of certain words (D'Andrade, 1991; Marikyan, Papagiannidis, & Alamanos, 2019). Thus, a document categorisation was conducted by cross-tabulating the extracted indexes against each document to identify their dominant features and label them accordingly (Davi et al., 2005). The labelled documents were then used as inputs of the classifier to train the algorithms. WordStat generated different combinations of classifier algorithms and cross-validation methods to identify the best performing set. The classifier used in this review was a *k*-Nearest Neighbour algorithm, validated by a 10-fold cross-validator method. The algorithm determined a class label by searching for the *k* most similar documents and then sharing their dominant label (Zhai & Massung, 2016).

3. Profile of the Customer Journey Literature

The Theory-Context-Construct-Methodology (TCCM) framework (Paul & Rosado-Serrano, 2019) was adopted to provide an overview of the customer journey literature. The bibliographic

sources, most cited articles, commonly applied theories, studied contexts, researched variables and employed methods of the retrieved articles are summarised in tables 1 to 6.

INSERT TABLES 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 and 6

Although the initial search result showed that the first article that used the term customer journey or touchpoint was published in 1991, the earliest article that met all the review criteria was published in 1999. The number of published journal articles that met the review criteria grew from 18 at the end of 2012 to 147 in May 2020, which represented an approximately seven-fold increase. The total number of publications in 2019 and the first five months of 2020 exceeded the amount that was published from 2015 to 2018 combined. The 147 retrieved articles were published in 65 different academic journals (Table 1). Prior to 2011, Journal of Direct, Data and Digital Marketing Practice and Harvard Business Review were the major sources, published almost half of the literature. The three main journals that published more than a third of the literature after 2018 were Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science, Journal of Retailing, and Journal of Business Research. The ten most cited articles among the retrieved papers are listed in Table 2.

Out of the 147 retrieved articles, 53 studies applied at least one theory to explain customer behaviour or service process in the context of the customer journey. The literature set included 46 different theories (Table 3), with the most frequently applied theories being game theory and social practice theory. From 93 and 83 articles that explicitly stated their researched industrial context and geographic scope respectively, the most frequently studied industries were tourism, and financial services and insurances, whilst United States and United Kingdom were the commonly studied locations. Other regularly researched contexts are shown in Table 4.

Table 5 displays the method used in the customer journey articles over time. The current set of the literature predominantly employed qualitative methodologies, which were beneficial in conceptual and instrumental development and reflected the early stage of the research in the domain (Johnson, Onwuegbuzie, & Turner, 2007). This reasoning is supported by the dearth of quantitative papers on the customer journey prior to 2014. Out of 95 articles that utilised a qualitative methodology, half of them were conceptual papers while the other half were empirical studies. The common qualitative methods used to collect empirical data included interviews, focus groups, ethnography, and diaries. There were 44 studies that adopted a quantitative approach and collected data by using surveys, company databases or real-time tracking. The researched variables in the retrieved quantitative articles are categorised and listed in Table 6. Most of the quantitative studies investigated customer-related variables from the customer's viewpoint. Although mixed methodologies were less popular, the approach was becoming more common after 2016.

4. Quantitative Content Analysis

The results of the clustering analysis reflected the use of terminologies in different topics, as well as the wording within the same texts (Yeh et al., 2012). The analysis produced a dendrogram of frequently occurring terms (Figure 2). The agglomeration results revealed five major themes, labelled *service satisfaction, failure and recovery, customer response, co-creation, channels,* and *technological disruption*. The identified themes reflected the research trends in customer journey studies. The terms within the branches comprise detailed features of the themes. They highlight factors and concepts that are commonly considered in the literature regarding the topics.

INSERT FIGURE 2

The learning algorithm was then employed to classify the retrieved articles. The frequency of the predicted classes is also displayed under each theme in Figure 2. The dominant classes of

the customer journey literature were *service satisfaction, failure and recovery*, and *channels*, which consisted of 48 and 36 studies respectively. Twenty-five and twenty-three papers each investigated *co-creation* and *customer response*. The less explored and relatively emerging theme in the customer journey literature was *technological disruption*, which 17 articles focused on. Table 7 summarises a publication pattern of the customer journey literature overtime.

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5. The Five Themes of the Customer Journey Literature

This section discusses the relevant literature for each of the five identified themes of the customer journey literature, namely *service satisfaction, failure and recovery, customer response*, *co-creation, channels* and *technological disruption.*

5.1 Service satisfaction, failure and recovery

Customers continuously adjust their perceptions of a brand at every touchpoint they encounter (Meyer & Schwager, 2007). A series of customer interactions with touchpoints over an extended period, which starts before and ends after the actual transaction, accumulate to a service evaluation of a customer (Kotni, 2017). A fulfilled interaction contribute to customer satisfaction (Halvorsrud, Kvale, & Følstad, 2016), whilst confused and frustrating interactions may lead to customer dissatisfaction and an increase in a churn rate (Ieva & Ziliani, 2018a). The customer journey is the actual process which represents the formation of customer experience and facilitates the understanding of how customer goals, expectation and behaviours evolve over time (Olson et al., 2019; Sultan, 2018). The concept of customer journeys is especially useful for companies that are trying to match their services with customer expectations.

The service satisfaction, failure and recovery stream of the customer journey literature focuses

on critical touchpoints and their sequences that positively or negatively contribute to a service evaluation of a customer in a customer journey. The stream comprises of three sub-themes. Customer satisfaction focuses on a static cognitive evaluation of the customer that serves as a building block to understand customer experience in the customer journey (Lemon & Verhoef, 2016). Service failure and recovery concerns problematic touchpoints or a structure of a journey and mechanisms to reverse the adverse consequences. Lastly, service mapping recognises a customer journey not only as a mean to understand customer experience but also a tool to design it (Canfield & Basso, 2017).

5.1.1 *Customer satisfaction*

Customer satisfaction has primarily been conceptualised as an alignment between service delivery and customer expectation. Customers are satisfied when their expected values of a product, a service or a relationship are achieved (Lee, Lanting, & Rojdamrongratana, 2017). Attaining and maintaining a high level of customer satisfaction is a critical indicator reflecting the performance of the company (Tseng, Qinhai, & su, 1999). A gratifying customer evaluation brought about positive word of mouth, customer retention and intention to repurchase, which leads to longstanding relationships and profitability (Koetz, 2019; Marino & Presti, 2018).

Customers derive satisfaction and dissatisfaction from interactions with various touchpoints, such as employees, website interfaces and online communities, along a customer journey (Lim et al., 2015). The term touchpoint refers to service encounters that a customer engages with and, directly or indirect, relates to a given brand, thereby affecting customer perceptions and evaluations of the brand in general and the customer journey in particular (Baxendale, Macdonald, & Wilson, 2015; Clatworthy, 2011). The interactions can be verbal or non-verbal, and sometimes outside of the company's control (Ieva & Ziliani, 2018a). Customers interact with a touchpoint with a goal or task in their mind (Voorhees et al., 2017). Every contact at a

touchpoint can lead to either a positive or negative brand evaluation by the customers, depending on the discrepancy between the touchpoint performance and customer expectations (Følstad & Kvale, 2018b). Therefore, companies have to systematically measure and monitor their interactions with customers at all touchpoints across the entire customer journey (Aichner & Gruber, 2017). The customer-centric assessment of the service quality is beneficial for companies in designing a service process (Kranzbühler, Kleijnen, Morgan, & Teerling, 2018). The obtained understanding of customer expectations and reactions facilitates the improvement of the quality of interactions and strengthens relationships with the customers (McKechnie et al., 2011). A minimised gap between touchpoint performance and customer expectations increases customer satisfaction and, thus, enhances the competitive advantage of the company (Halvorsrud et al., 2016).

5.1.2 *Service failure and recovery*

Service failures are interruptions that make customers deviate from their regular journey (Van Vaerenbergh, Varga, De Keyser, & Orsingher, 2019). They could be occurrences of unplanned touchpoints, missing touchpoints, touchpoint breakdowns or irregularities in touchpoint sequence (Halvorsrud et al., 2016). Failures can occur at any phase of the journey and cause either momentary or enduring adverse impacts on customer experience (Lemon & Verhoef, 2016). A service interruption temporarily raises customer expectations on the service quality, thereby narrowing their zone of tolerance (Van Vaerenbergh et al., 2019). Poor service experience induces customers to churn and makes the brand less attractive to prospective customers due to negative word of mouth (Patti, van Dessel, & Hartley, 2020). However, a similar negative incident may pose different consequences for various brands, depending on the efficiency of their recovery mechanisms and relationship quality. Nevertheless, service failures are often treated as a discrete event, which neglects the temporal dimension and limits the effectiveness of recovery (Van Vaerenbergh et al., 2019). Instead, companies need to have

a means that makes it possible for them to systematically monitor the development of the negative experience and promptly address it (Panzera et al., 2017; Rosenbaum, Otalora, & Ramírez, 2017). Successful service recovery can overturn the crisis, impress the customers and enhance customer loyalty to the brand (Palmer & Bejou, 2016).

Customers are constantly adjusting their expectation levels through their relationship stages with a company, which makes the moment that a service failure occurs a determinant of its consequences (Meyer & Schwager, 2007). Engaged customers who are committed and have emotionally invested in the brand for a long time are likely to stay after the interruption as they find it harder to break off and migrate to a competing brand, whilst customers in the early stage of a relationship may be forgiving and find a justification to validate their choice. The most volatile groups are those in the middle stage of their lifecycle, who have not yet built sufficient trust in and commitment to the company (Kanuri & Andrews, 2019; Palmer & Bejou, 2016). Procedural, financial and relational costs are barriers that discourage customers from switching behaviour (Sultan, 2019). However, a repeated failure can severely affect the experience of the customer in all stages of the lifecycle and motivate them to take unfavourable actions against the brand. Therefore, companies need to address service failure in a timely manner. Real-Time recovery management does not only minimise the adverse impacts but also creates a better customer impression (Følstad & Kvale, 2018a). Furthermore, the customer lifetime management, by which a company customises its offers to match with customer stages, enables the dynamic aspect of customer management and thereby strengthens their relationship with the customers (Lee et al., 2017; Ponsignon, Smart, & Phillips, 2018). The way a company handles a complaint is a critical determinant of its relationship with the customer, and is closely linked to customer satisfaction, commitment and trust (Kranzbühler et al., 2018).

5.1.3 *Service mapping*

Companies that strive to improve customer experience need to build capacity for structurally monitoring touchpoints and assessing customer experience through the entire consumption process (Følstad & Kvale, 2018b; Ieva & Ziliani, 2018b). It is their job to critically analyse the impact of different experiential factors and closely monitor customers' cognitive, emotional and behavioural responses in each and every stage of the consumption (Edelman & Singer, 2015). The customer journey mapping is an important customer-centric approach that helps companies to improve and manage the service delivery process by visualising all touchpoints that are both encountered and unseen by the customer but contribute toward the customer experience (Canfield & Basso, 2017; Halvorsrud et al., 2016). The more touchpoints in the service process, the more complicated and necessary for companies to map customer journeys (Richardson, 2010). The approach is effective in identifying critical satisfying moments and revealing problematic incoherence in the service process (Aoki, Obeng, Borders, & Lester, 2019; Rawson et al., 2013). It provides a dynamic view of customer needs and uncovers customer expectations hidden inside customer data (Bhide, Negi, Subramaniam, & Gupta, 2009).

There is no definite procedure to collect touchpoint data and map a journey. The metrics that measure customer responses and experiences in a journey are broadly categorised into perception-based, operational based and outcome-based (Patti et al., 2020). The indicators of success and failure of an individual touchpoint can range from its contribution to positive customer attitude, wait time to related number of complaints (Baxendale et al., 2015; Panzera et al., 2017; Sultan, 2019). Companies have flexibility in customising the approach to suit their purposes (Richardson, 2010). Nonetheless, a useful customer journey mapping often contains consumption stages, touchpoints, customer responses and critical experiential factors (Becker & Jaakkola, 2020; McKechnie, Grant, & Shabbir Golawala, 2011). Companies can combine and recombine the knowledge extracted from the mapping of customer journey to tailor their

service delivery process to enhance customer experience and create competitive advantages (Lee et al., 2017; Peltier, Zahay, & Krishen, 2013). The insights enable the company to design a touchpoint sequence that improves customers satisfaction while minimising dissatisfying moments (George & Wakefield, 2018; Norton & Pine II, 2013). A well-designed service process pays particular attention to the moments in a customer journey that are most responsive to customer experience (Meyer & Schwager, 2007; Muskat et al., 2013). Hence, customer journey mapping is useful for companies in both service improvement and new service development (Zomerdijk & Voss, 2011).

The recent technological advances and the interest in "big data" have led companies to collect an unprecedent volume and variety of customer information (Patti et al., 2020). However, ubiquitous customer data can pose challenges for companies in managing and integrating the unstructured data, which calls for a transition in organisation structures and processes to ensure consistency across touchpoints in all phases of the journey to match the growing customer expectation of a seamless experience (Kuehnl, Jozic, & Homburg, 2019; Piccoli, Brohman, Watson, & Parasuraman, 2009). An operational shift and an investment in information technology systems help to diminish data fragmentation and promote an aggregated customer-centric framework to appreciate the communication synergies (Blackie, 2015; Edelman & Singer, 2015). An integrative metric that temporally tracks efficiency, quality, satisfaction and behaviours of customers is also important in the experiential retail environment (Voorhees et al., 2017). The success of a company in an information rich era depends on its ability to analyse customer data, deliver authentic customer experience across all channels and co-create offerings based on knowledge about customers (Croteau & Li, 2003; Lee et al., 2017).

5.2 Customer response

Customer response is an individual reaction to an interaction with a touchpoint. The interaction can be either direct or indirect and occurs through various touchpoints, such as a product, an employee or technology (Stein & Ramaseshan, 2016). Customers perceive each touchpoint as satisfying, dissatisfying or neutral based on their execution. The dissatisfying and satisfying encounters are referred to as pain and pleasure moments, respectively (Kranzbühler, Kleijnen, & Verlegh, 2019). Mapping a customer journey has the distinctive advantage of presenting insightful information about customer experience that may appear unimportant when assessed by other methods (Crosier & Handford, 2012). The customer journey captures in-depth reactions of customers by monitoring their thoughts, feelings and behaviours in response to the retail environment at different stages of a journey (Zomerdijk & Voss, 2010). The customer responses extracted from the mapping of a customer journey are critical information for designing the service environment to customer experience (Stein & Ramaseshan, 2016).

The fundamental focus of customer responses in the customer journey literature is an exploration of the reactions of customers to touchpoint elements that impact on customer experience. This aspect is divided into two perspectives. The customers' viewpoint focuses on cognitive and emotional assessments that influence customer evaluation of the customer journey. On the other hand, the companies' perspective focuses on multi-sensory touchpoints and the service atmosphere that drive customer responses. Companies design their touchpoints and service delivery process to trigger favourable customer responses and create an outstanding customer journey that promotes positive brand perception (Zomerdijk & Voss, 2010).

5.2.1 *Customer perception*

Customer responses are the cognitive and emotional assessment of customer experiences. The cognitive aspect refers to customer awareness of the content being delivered while emotions measure customer feelings about the consumption (Crosier & Handford, 2012; Klaus, 2013).

Brand awareness that is built in the earlier stage of a customer journey can significantly influence the final choice and holistic experience of customers (Cheng, Anderson, Zhu, & Choi, 2018). The awareness-building activities during the initial contacts are critical touchpoints to increase the spending and satisfaction of customers (Khanna, Jacob, & Yadav, 2014). Although the cognitive and emotional responses are two separated agencies that are tightly intertwined, the emotional aspect has often been explained in terms of cognitions (Chen et al., 2008; Kuuru & Närvänen, 2019). Customers perceive a range of emotions, both positive and negative, through interactions across different phases of the journey. Positive and strong emotions contribute to a meaningful experience and reinforce relationship building. Customers that feel pleased, aroused or in control are more likely to remain in the service setting and are willing to spend more time and money there (Clarke, Perry, & Denson, 2012). Furthermore, the emotions and feelings that a customer individually experiences can affect the perceptions of other customers through expressions, movements and gestures (Kuuru & Närvänen, 2019). Customer experience is formed through a continuous negotiation and perception of thoughts and feelings arising from all interactions in the customer journey (Kuuru & Närvänen, 2019). Responses from an individual touchpoint carry over to the next interaction and influence the subsequent reactions (Stein & Ramaseshan, 2019). They collectively shape customer beliefs about performance and the attractiveness of the brand and this consequently influences their attitudes and purchase intentions (Chen et al., 2008; Kranzbühler et al., 2019).

Digital technology has recently demonstrated an increasing influence on customer response by mediating the way customers perceive and share their experience. The ability to communicate and exchange cognitive and affective information reduces perceived risks, increases engagement and builds the emotional connections of the customers (Klaus, 2013; Stein & Ramaseshan, 2016). Customers utilise technology to help them recall details about a journey while using social media to seek social approval both before and after the purchase (Hall &

Towers, 2017). An exposure to opinions and common preferences of people on the social media prior to making a decision can influence the final choice of customers (Hildebrand & Schlager, 2019). However, customer responses are complex and there is no ultimate service design that fits in every context (Stein & Ramaseshan, 2019). The same touchpoint can impose different effects on different individuals depending on their motivations, goals, social and cultural contexts (Barari & Furrer, 2018; Shavitt & Barnes, 2020). Therefore, companies must be aware of the complexity and not oversimplify customer responses (Rosenbaum, Ramírez, & Matos, 2019).

5.2.2 *Service environment*

The five senses are recognized as critical information transmitters in the customer journey (Zomerdijk & Voss, 2010). The service environment contains an array of environmental stimuli, ranging from the ambience, space to symbols. These stimuli influence the approach and avoidance behaviours of customers and thereby impact on the formation of their experience (Ponsignon, Durrieu, & Bouzdine-Chameeva, 2017; Rosenbaum et al., 2019). Both tangible and symbolic aspects of service settings are critical to customer perceptions (Barari & Furrer, 2018). Well-designed functionalities and the layout of the setting help customers to move through their journey and accomplish their goals with ease and comfort (Ellway, 2014), while the psychological and social elements enhance awareness and provide spiritual experiences to customers (Hemetsberger, Kreuzer, & Klien, 2019). The service stimuli have important roles in capturing attention, providing embodied experiences and motivating the participation of customers (Kuuru & Närvänen, 2019). Well-developed surroundings and atmosphere stimulate favourable responses while abating negative perceptions that potentially damage the trust and goodwill of the customers (Clarke et al., 2012).

All touchpoints from the start to the end of the service delivery process must communicate consistent values and messages to support the formation of brand associations (Vredeveld & Coulter, 2019; Zomerdijk & Voss, 2010). Customers utilise different judgement strategies to process the wide range of information that they encounter across the journey (Santana, Thomas, & Morwitz, 2020). The coherence in the process underlines connections between diverse brand attributes and service stimuli, which reinforce customers' learning and enhance their perceptions toward the brand (Kranzbühler et al., 2019; Stone, Machtynger, & Machtynger, 2015). The design of the service delivery process should support the perspective, movement and pacing of customers during their navigation (Ellway, 2014). Brands should also provide clear, concise, and credible information to prevent confusion and the risk of customers dropping out (De Vries, Rietkerk, & Kooger, 2019). Customers expect to navigate around the service process at their own pace with some hint of direction to minimise time pressures and cognitive effort (Clarke et al., 2012; Zomerdijk & Voss, 2010). Furthermore, companies have to be aware of changes that are imposed by the dynamic technological development to keep their service delivery process relevant to customer expectations (Klaus, 2013; Stein & Ramaseshan, 2016). They can also consider outsourcing dissatisfying touchpoints that are difficult or costly to improve to another party in the hope of shifting the blame from the focal brand (Kranzbühler et al., 2019).

5.3 Co-creation

Co-creation emerges from the collaborative process and interrelationship among members in the service ecosystem (Bolton et al., 2014). This perspective emphasises the creation and destruction of values through interactions between a customer and a brand (Åkesson et al., 2014). The understanding of the co-creation process in the context of the customer journey reveals significant elements that contribute to memorable customer experiences (Micheaux & Bosio, 2019; Trischler & Zehrer, 2012).

Co-creation in the context of the customer journey literature mainly discusses the role of the service network and customers that contribute to the formation of customer experience. This aspect recognises companies and customers as value-proposing actors, who add value through their resources and participation in the process (Barile, Ciasullo, Troisi, & Sarno, 2017). Companies provide service interfaces with communicational and interactional touchpoints, while customers apply their skills and knowledge to utilise the service encounters, co-create value and personalise their experience along the customer journey (Bolton et al., 2014; McColl-Kennedy et al., 2015).

5.3.1 *Network and process of co-creation*

According to the concept of co-creation from a service dominant logic perspective, the service delivery network is a complex set of relationships among various actors, whose interactions and interdependencies co-create value and influence the responses of each other (Varnali, 2019). Although this service perspective reduces the control of companies in their operations (Bijmolt et al., 2019), companies are responsible for equipping prerequisites such as information and engagement platforms to enable the co-creation process (Barile et al., 2017). However, the optimal degree of intervention, the core value and the content that companies provide to customers can vary through different phases of the journey depending on customer goals (Demmers, Weltevreden, & van Dolen, 2020). A greater level of customer engagement does not always enhance customer experience (Pallant, Sands, & Karpen, 2020), while a reduction in the involvement of the customers is also not always favourable (Rebecca Hamilton et al., 2019). Therefore, companies must have flexibility in their roles to maximise the perceived value of customers throughout the process (Thomas, Epp, & Price, 2019). In general, companies have to orchestrate their mutually dependent touchpoints to jointly facilitate the exchange and integration of resources to stimulate value co-creation within the service network (Breidbach, Brodie, & Hollebeek, 2014; Schlegelmilch & Simbrunner, 2019). Such service

planning requires a holistic understanding of a company's offerings that can affect value co-creation and appropriation activities (Botschen & Wegerer, 2017; Stockwell, 2015). The matching role of companies to customer goals in the co-creation process can reduce uncertainty and motivate customers to assume the role of co-creators (Wollenburg, Holzapfel, & Hübner, 2019).

The co-creation perspective in the customer journey presents challenges for traditional marketing to pursue more customer-centric strategies that may involve changes in the value proposition and value delivery designs of the companies (McColl-Kennedy et al., 2015). Companies must know their customers and approach them in an engaging, non-intrusive and congruent way to promote partnerships within the value network (Nyström & Mickelsson, 2019; Yachin, 2018). Companies can increase customer participation by improving the process to be more in line with customer preferences, making the activities more attractive while reducing associated costs and required effort by the customers (Dellaert, 2019; Mangiaracina et al., 2009). Awards and punishments can also be used to incentivise customers (Nakata et al., 2019). Successful value co-creation processes require companies to integrate the service system, be transparent and share relevant information in a timely manner with their customers to facilitate the collaborative process (Micheaux & Bosio, 2019; Wollenburg et al., 2019). Brands can also leverage innovative touchpoints and advanced analytics to provide customers with real-time support, insightful data and digital security (Bijmolt et al., 2019; Tax, McCutcheon, & Wilkinson, 2013). A shift from a traditional dyadic company-to-customer value delivery to value co-creation extends the interaction between companies and customers beyond transactions, which provides customer feedback and contributes to the customer relationship management performance for the business (Marino & Presti, 2018; McColl-Kennedy, Zaki, Lemon, Urmetzer, & Neely, 2019).

5.3.2 *Customer participation in the co-creation process*

Customers have become co-creators, rather than mere consumers of products and services, whose emotional involvement plays a critical role in co-constructing the service experience (Varnali, 2019). This transformation in the role of customers has reinforced the importance of interaction, value-in-use and customer experience over product quality, especially in experience intensive industries (Nyström & Mickelsson, 2019; Yachin, 2018). Customers frequently seek unique offers that serve their individual preferences and needs. They utilise multiple touchpoints according to their own interests and motivations to personalise their experience along the journey and generate data in response (Tax et al., 2013). Customer participation in the process can enhance welfare by allowing more diverse products and services that match their needs (Dellaert, 2019). Customers' involvement is driven by self-determination to feel competent and belong to a brand community (Pallant et al., 2020). The extent of customer co-creation behaviours greatly depends on their trust, loyalty and prior experiences with the company (Nakata et al., 2019). Perceived control over the process and outcomes also plays a critical role in determining customer co-creation intention. Customers feel more comfortable when they can decide on their pace, direction and privacy (Åkesson et al., 2014). In general, the effectiveness of customers in a co-creation process is defined by their familiarity, as well as the reliability of the service process (Tax et al., 2013).

Technological advances have offered new and extended forms of interaction between customers and companies (Marino & Presti, 2018). They equip customers with information and tools to play an active role in the experience formation of not only themselves but also other customers in the service network (Barile et al., 2017; McColl-Kennedy et al., 2015). Digital platforms and mobile devices provide customers with easy access to extensive support and improve the learning process while promoting social interaction and the public recognition benefits of co-creation (Dellaert, 2019; Marino & Presti, 2018). However, the extensive range

of touchpoints can leave customers feel overwhelmed and complicate the interactions (Pallant et al., 2020). Customers increasingly expect to have control over their media exposure and the selection of touchpoints in the journey (Nyström & Mickelsson, 2019).

5.4 Channels

Customers accumulate experiences through a vast range of channels available in the service environment, such as physical stores, mobile devices and social networking sites (Barwitz & Maas, 2018). Channels offer various touchpoints that mediate communications and interactions between customers and companies. Technological advances have expanded the spectrum of the interactive mediums and increased complexity in the customer journey (Wolny & Charoensuksai, 2014). The emerging touchpoints and channels have offered more flexibility to customers while increasing the complication in channel management for the company (van der Veen & van Ossenbruggen, 2015). Therefore, a thorough understanding of the emerging engagement platforms and changing customer channel behaviours is valuable for companies when managing the customer journey and creating a holistic customer experience (Hosseini, Merz, Röglinger, & Wenninger, 2018; Li & Kannan, 2014).

Past studies on channels have mainly focused on customer behaviour and the factors that contribute to the complex and dynamic decisions that customers encounter in the service system. The theme comprises two sub-topics, labelled channel behaviour and channel management. The customer channel behaviour branch focuses on channel usage and customers' preferences in their decision-making process. Channel management addresses the service design practice of the companies in attempting to develop customer journeys that provide outstanding customer experience.

5.4.1 *Customer channel behaviour*

Customers tend to behave heterogeneously and use different channels for specific reasons (Gao, Melero, & Sese, 2019). They continuously assess their experience and reconsider their channel choice through the entire course of the journey (Anderl, Schumann, & Kunz, 2016). Customer channel choice is driven by the value-in-use, which is the perceived usefulness and the benefits that customers seek from their interactions (Barwitz & Maas, 2018). When selecting a channel, customers evaluate search costs, opportunity costs and cognitive effort against potential risk reduction and comfort (Li & Kannan, 2014). Therefore, they are likely to interact with channels that they are more familiar with to reduce the associated effort and perceived risk (Anderl, Becker, von Wangenheim, & Schumann, 2016; Hickman, Kharouf, & Sekhon, 2019). However, channel preferences may vary across the different journey phases and stages of the relationship with a company due to different needs, goals and shopping values of the customer (Ballestar, Grau-Carles, & Sainz, 2018; Scholz, Brenner, & Hinz, 2019). In general, customers constantly select the options that offer the highest perceived value-in-use and allow them to navigate through a journey in the way that best corresponds to their goal (Hosseini et al., 2018; Kerr & Kelly, 2019).

Customer channel behaviour has evolved with the development of the internet and digital platforms (Lynch & Barnes, 2020). The proliferation of channels has increased the complexity of the customer journey from the perspective of companies but provides rich interaction options for customers to use through the decision-making process (Huré, Picot-Coupey, & Ackermann, 2017; Wolny & Charoensuksai, 2014). Customers have an unprecedented freedom to shape their journey (Herhausen, Kleinlercher, Verhoef, Emrich, & Rudolph, 2019). Technology has also enabled customers to switch and integrate channels more easily than ever (Hu & Tracogna, 2020). In the omnichannel environment, customers no longer complete their journey exclusively in one channel and expect companies to unify the various channels into a seamless experience (Gao et al., 2019). Customers can start a journey by visiting physical stores to test

products but place an order on a website. Alternatively, they can obtain information from a commercial website before purchasing from a physical store. These contemporary channel behaviours are known as showrooming and webrooming, respectively (Jocevski, Arvidsson, Miragliotta, Ghezzi, & Mangiaracina, 2019; Viejo-Fernández, Sanzo-Pérez, & Vázquez-Casielles, 2019). Mobile devices play an instrumental role in fostering showrooming behaviour as they enable customers to search online while in a physical store to compare choices and find the best option. This phenomenon is recognised as mobile showrooming (Viejo-Fernández, Sanzo-Pérez, & Vázquez-Casielles, 2020). Furthermore, mobile devices also contribute to the "want-it-here-want-it-now" mentality of customers, which lessens their willingness to compromise on the way they utilise multiple channels in their journeys (Faulds, Mangold, Raju, & Valsalan, 2018).

The information and familiarity with a brand that customers accumulate through each interaction can be carried over and spilled over to consecutive channels. Previous channel exposure can reduce the cost of interaction as a result of lock-in effects, exposure effects, learning effects and risk reduction (Li & Kannan, 2014; Nakano & Kondo, 2018). However, if the channels are highly divergent or offer contradictory information, customers may drop out due to frustration and confusion (Anderl, Becker, et al., 2016). The customer usage of multiple channels does not always convey pleasure in shopping. It can also reveal the difficulty in the process and the risk avoidance behaviour of the customers (van der Veen & van Ossenbruggen, 2015). Therefore, companies have to emphasise channel congruity to help customers retrieve information from memory and promote coherence among their channel offerings (Gao et al., 2019).

5.4.2 *Channel management*

Customer decision-making is now a continuous process rather than discrete activities. Customers evaluate service delivery and the quality of their relationship with companies based on interactions with multiple channels (Cassab & MacLachlan, 2009). This change in customer behaviour leads to a downturn of the traditional single-channel approach and requires companies to adopt a more holistic mindset to influence the entire customer journey (Faulds et al., 2018). Companies are expanding their channel portfolio in the hope of offering greater value-in-use and increasing opportunities to interact with customers, which thereby improves the customer acquisition and retention rate (Fornari et al., 2016). A restriction to a certain platform can exclude potential synergies between channels and understate the evolving omnichannel customer behaviour (Rudkowski, Heney, Yu, Sedlezky, & Gunn, 2020; Yumurtacı Hüseyinoğlu, Galipoğlu, & Kotzab, 2017). Therefore, companies should not deliberately migrate customers from one channel to another by increasing the difficulty of accessing the current preferable channel (van der Veen & van Ossenbruggen, 2015). Instead, they should leverage a range of channels to provide customers with seamless channel transition opportunities, aiming to minimise possible negative channel synergies while enhancing lock-in effects (Hu & Tracogna, 2020).

However, an investment in new channels and the operation of multiple channels can be expensive and pose challenges, such as the migration effect and channel cannibalisation, if not properly implemented or managed (Fornari et al., 2016; Romaniuk, Beal, & Uncles, 2013). The roles and value-in-use of each channel may also change as the retail environment and customer behaviour evolve (Steward, Narus, Roehm, & Ritz, 2019). These challenges have given rise to an omnichannel strategy as an approach for companies to manage their channel offerings and cope with the dynamic customer expectations (Hickman et al., 2019). A complete alignment of different channels requires a holistic understanding of companies in customer

journeys and systemic adjustments in the strategies of all individual touchpoints within the brand ecosystem (Huré et al., 2017).

Technology has enabled companies to collect customer data more easily than ever (Li & Kannan, 2014). The customer knowledge generated at touchpoints creates opportunities for companies to actively listen to their customers and extract insightful information for strategic planning (De Keyser, Schepers, & Konuş, 2015; Schröder, Falke, Hruschka, & Reutterer, 2019). The collected information from such sources enables companies to better profile their customers, customise touchpoints for specific segments and serve them in a way that promotes customer loyalty (Herhausen et al., 2019; Nunes, Bellin, Lee, & Schunck, 2013). However, raw data is usually unstructured, fragmented and incompatible for actionable planning (Dhebar, 2013; Manser Payne, Peltier, & Barger, 2017). Companies have to integrate their database fully and precisely measure the incremental value of individual touchpoints along with their interactions in the customer journey (Danaher & Van Heerde, 2018). This information can enable companies to quantify the contribution of each touchpoint, avoid overlapping campaigns and optimise budget allocation (Kannan, Reinartz, & Verhoef, 2016). The digital and omnichannel retail environment requires companies to become information intensive and utilise technology in strategic service design (Peterson, Gröne, Kammer, & Kirscheneder, 2010; Straker, Wrigley, & Rosemann, 2015).

5.5 Technological Disruption

Technological advance has resulted in an abundance of new innovative touchpoints that overcome time and location constraints in the service environment (Majra, Saxena, Jha, & Jagannathan, 2016). The introduction of new technologies, channels and devices has significantly transformed the way customers experience services and interact along their journey (Flavián, Ibáñez-Sánchez, & Orús, 2019). Brands are also increasingly utilising

technologies in their operations to enhance service experience (Del Bucchia, Miltgen, Russell, & Burlat, 2020). The success of companies in the digital era relies on their abilities to track and comprehend the service offering as a whole and be responsive to their value creation and delivery process (Kannan & Li, 2017). Companies have to be aware of the new roles and interdependency between distinct touchpoints and their contributions to the customer experience to manage the customer journey effectively (Paluch & Tuzovic, 2019).

Research in the technological disruption stream has focused on the impact of technological advances on the service environment, customer behaviour and the structure of the customer journey. The theme was divided into two dimensions. The innovative touchpoints dimension investigated the emergence of digital technologies, while the customer technology adoption dimension focused on the responses of customers to the technological advances.

5.5.1 *Innovative touchpoints*

Innovative touchpoints, such as self-service kiosks, mobile devices and wearable technologies, enable companies to provide values, connect with customers and deliver experiences in a new fundamental way that increases sales and relationship-building opportunities (Del Bucchia et al., 2020; Ryan Hamilton, Ferraro, Haws, & Mukhopadhyay, 2020). The recent technological development that integrates a virtual and a real-world environment, such as virtual reality and augmented reality, has "embedded, embodied and extended" customer experiences (Hilken et al., 2018). The technologically-enabled touchpoints provide real-time, interactive and multisensory experience to customers by overlaying a virtual object into the physical world or fully immersing the user in a virtual world (Farah, Ramadan, & Harb, 2019; Hollebeek, Clark, Andreassen, Sigurdsson, & Smith, 2020). The integration does not only offer a sense of authenticity and realism to customers but also closes the channel gap between online and offline channels, thus enhancing seamless experience (Hilken et al., 2018). Furthermore, the

technological embodiment that involves integration between the human body and a device also generates strong emotional bonds to customers due to its immersive capacity and sensory attachment (Flavián et al., 2019; Tyrväinen & Karjaluoto, 2019). These innovative touchpoints assist companies in collecting more accurate and granular customer data at a precise time and location, which helps to deepen the understanding of customer behaviour and personalise real-time offers (Singh, Nambisan, Bridge, & Brock, 2020).

However, the digital technologies have changed the service landscape and pose challenges to businesses. The embodied digital information in an offline retail setting disrupts how customers evaluate products from packaging and in-store promotions to content generated online on social media (Hilken et al., 2018). The increase in innovative touchpoints also disturbs the traditional marketing funnel, making some of the stages that customers go through when making a purchase decision obsolete (Farah & Ramadan, 2017). The customer decision making process is now a fluid journey that is not set in a certain chronological order (Grewal & Roggeveen, 2020). Overall, the emerging platforms and technologies challenge the relevance of existing touchpoints and the value chain of companies, demanding that they provide new service solutions to match the evolving customer expectations (Paluch & Tuzovic, 2019; Tyrväinen & Karjaluoto, 2019). It is necessary for companies to fully understand the impact of newly developed innovative touchpoints on customer values, expectations and attitudes to leverage on them effectively (Ryan Hamilton et al., 2020). Companies that adopt the technologies without a well-rounded strategy and customised content for targeting the audience may result in mismatched interface preferences and unnecessary interruptions in the flow of interactions, which leads to customer avoidance and switching behaviour (Farah et al., 2019; Singh et al., 2020).

5.5.2 *Customer technology adoption*

Technology has empowered customers to have a more dynamic and autonomous role in the formation of their experience (Flavián et al., 2019). Digital touchpoints give customers a newfound sense of control, with instantaneous access to information and the ability to shop anytime and anywhere (Tyrväinen & Karjaluoto, 2019). The ease and minimal costs in sharing experience and getting advice from the online community has significantly reduced the information asymmetries between customers and brands (Kannan & Li, 2017). Technology-enabled touchpoints that rely on the advance of self-service technologies also promote the co-creating role of customers (Vakulenko, Shams, Hellström, & Hjort, 2019). However, the autonomous and data-driven technologies can also threaten the sense of competence and free will of customers, leaving them feeling vulnerable (de Bellis & Johar, 2020). Customers only welcome technological-based interactions when they perceived them to be pertinent and customised to their needs, while irrelevant touchpoints can be recognized as an intrusion into their life (Del Bucchia et al., 2020).

Customer response to the introduction of new technologies can range from excitement to anxiety (Vakulenko et al., 2019). Innovative touchpoints that collect personal data and offer personalised recommendations raise suspicions and fear in customers driven by privacy concerns (Nam & Kannan, 2020; Vaghela, 2014). Intrusive brand messages in private spheres can create feelings of oppression and harassment that may eventually overpower customers' perceived sense of control and empowerment (Del Bucchia et al., 2020). The level of privacy influences customer perceptions of value, fairness, trust and satisfaction. Companies may reduce these concerns by clearly communicating the terms and conditions and offer transparent privacy policies to customers related to their services (Paluch & Tuzovic, 2019). Furthermore, the technology adoption rate can also increase if customers recognise the benefits. Customers are more likely to adopt a new technology if they believe that it will increase their shopping performance, make the journey more enjoyable without requiring huge efforts to use. However,

customers at different stages of channel adoption have different needs and technology readiness levels. First-time users may perceive a certain degree of confusion due to unfamiliarity, but experiences that accumulate over time can alleviate mistrust of new technological touchpoints (Vakulenko et al., 2019). Therefore, companies have to know their customers and tailor their touchpoints accordingly (Tyrväinen & Karjaluoto, 2019). The uneasiness caused by the novelty of an innovative touchpoint diminishes over time as it is transformed into a conventional core experience, which in turn increases the adoption rate (Flavián et al., 2019).

6. Suggestions for Future Research

A heat map was constructed to analyse the frequency and gaps in the customer journey literature (Figure 3). This analysis is useful in disclosing research trends of topics with a multidimensional nature (Davlembayeva, Papagiannidis, & Alamanos, 2019). The horizontal axis labels the three phases of the customer journey, namely the pre-purchase, purchase and post-purchase phase, while the vertical axis marks the five and eleven identified themes and sub-themes.

INSERT FIGURE 3

The development of the customer journey literature has been driven by an interest in the customer experience. Studies on service satisfaction, failure and recovery accounted for nearly half of the retrieved literature set. Service satisfaction, failure and recovery during transactions and channels in the pre-purchase phase received the most attention from the scholars in the past two decades. Customer response and the emerging technological disruptions were relatively underexplored. The analysis showed that the literature set mainly focused on the purchase phase while less emphasis has been put on the other two stages of the journey. Although co-creation has been studied in the customer journey context to some extent, most of the studies focused on the customer participation and disregarded the network and process

dimension of the theme. In general, the after-sales activities have received the least research attention of all the themes.

6.1 Research agenda for the five themes

INSERT TABLE 8

Service satisfaction, failure and recovery: In the early years, the research on service satisfaction, failure and recover in the context of the customer journey narrowly focused on the core service delivery process and neglected the other two phases of the journey, which restricted the understanding about critical moments that contribute to customer experience (Blackie, 2015; Vaghela, 2014). Therefore, a broader consideration that reinforce a holistic view of the customer consumption process is encouraged in the hope of advancing understandings in the domain (Voorhees et al., 2017). Future research that investigate the evolvement of customer's goals and expectations, as well as compare impact of various touchpoints in different phases of the journey would provide insights into the development of customer service evaluation in the customer journey. Although a few studies have examined procedures of customer journey mapping (e.g. Berman (2020), Panzera et al. (2017) and Tseng et al. (1999)), the understanding remains fragmented. Thus, there is a need to review and integrate the knowledge about customer journey mapping. Furthermore, the customer journey does not always follow a linear and sequential pattern (Ellway, 2014; Wolny & Charoensuksai, 2014), future research may consider alternative structures of the journey. Lastly, researchers are encouraged to investigate other contexts of the customer journey beyond a purchase journey, such as a search journey and a customer support journey.

Customer response: The customer journey literature has heavily focused on customer perception and service environment in the purchase phase. Customer response has often been investigated in cognitive terms and neglected the unfolding of the emotional aspect (Kuuru &

Närvänen, 2019). Scholars are encouraged to further investigate the development of the feelings and sensations of customers and their interrelations with the cognitive and behavioural responses throughout the journey. Studies on emotional responses are particularly important with the growing popularity of technological embodiment. Additionally, the integration of technologies into a service environment has imposed challenges for both the service environment and customer perception aspect of the customer journey. Future research should investigate changes in the constitution of service attributes and how they alter customer perceptions of their interactions (Ellway, 2014). Additionally, an investigation on how customer responses in one phase are carried over to the next, affecting cumulative customer perception, is also an area of research interest (Santana et al., 2020). Researchers should also incorporate or distinctively investigate customer response in the post-purchase phase of the journey to enrich the scant literature. Potential research areas include the effects of the increasing connectivity and interactivity in the service system on customer consumption evaluation and cross-selling opportunities for companies.

Co-creation: The changes in the value chain and roles of customers, as well as other actors in the service ecosystem, are encouraging researchers to shift their focus from one-way service delivery to co-creative relationships (McColl-Kennedy et al., 2015; Palmer & Bejou, 2016), especially with the rise of the sharing economy, which reduces the control of companies in the value creation process while further empowering the customers (Dellaert, 2019). More studies could investigate the changing responsibilities of companies in the new business environment and identify an optimal level of intervention to avoid unsolicited support that can hinder customer participation (Rebecca Hamilton et al., 2019). The co-creation perspective also extends the view on the value chain to consider more stakeholders that contribute to the formation of customer experience (Mangiaracina et al., 2009). Therefore, future research could consider the roles of these indirect touchpoints and how companies can intervene and influence

them in their favour. The ‘collective journey’ (Thomas et al., 2019), which studies the dynamic interplay between customer practices and retailer roles, is also a promising concept to explore to enhance the understanding of the co-creation process in the customer journey context. Empirical works that demonstrate the use of innovative touchpoints and advanced technological tools in relation to co-creative activities and processes also represent fruitful opportunities for both researchers and practitioners. Future research should also its study scope to cover the post-purchase phase and consider co-creation process (Pallant et al., 2020).

Channels: The expansion of the touchpoint array has made a simple classification (as either online and offline) inadequate for actionable planning (Nakano & Kondo, 2018). Scholars need to explore touchpoints at a higher-level and consider their interactions to develop knowledge about omnichannel management (Herhausen et al., 2019; Khanna et al., 2014). The advances in technology have also blurred the physical and virtual platforms (Kaczorowskaspychalska, 2017). Therefore, there is a need for studies that focus the integration of innovative and tradition touchpoints, such as the use of augmented reality in-store (Hilken et al., 2018), to explore the unprecedented opportunities for enhancing customer experience. More studies that extend the knowledge about showrooming and webrooming behaviour will also be helpful for practitioners in resource allocation (Hu & Tracogna, 2020). Furthermore, the current practice of customer segmentation relies strongly on the continuous changing characteristics of individual channels, which makes the results highly dependent on the research scope (Barwitz & Maas, 2018). Therefore, researchers should consider segmenting customers based on more stable elements such as their sociological and psychological descriptions (Manser Payne et al., 2017; Moon, Han, Chun, & Hong, 2016). Additionally, investigations on how customer channel behaviours evolve over the relationship period with the company and thus move to a new segmentation are also a potential area for further research. Future research needs not

neglect channels for the after-sales activities or it is a missed opportunity for customer retention and cross-selling.

Technological disruption: Technological disruption is an emerging theme in the context of the customer journey, with most of the related articles published after 2018. Digital advances have significantly changed the business landscape and elements of the customer journey. More studies, in line with Farah and Ramadan (2017), should investigate the impacts of innovative touchpoints, not just on customer expectations but actual behaviours that change the structure of the customer journey. Further research that addresses the growing concern of customers about their data privacy and how companies can guarantee protection would also be beneficial in understanding the evolving customer expectations (Paluch & Tuzovic, 2019; Singh et al., 2020). Scholars could examine the contextual-level and individual-level factors that stimulate customers to adopt (and prevent them from adopting) technological touchpoints (Del Bucchia et al., 2020; Flavián et al., 2019). Additionally, studies on the development of human and technological touchpoints would also be helpful for practitioners in addressing the challenges of the digital environment (de Bellis & Johar, 2020). In general, technological disruptions should be investigated with the other identified themes of the customer journey to broaden the awareness of their impacts and integrate the body of knowledge.

6.2 Theory, context, construct and methodology

Many studies of the customer journey are still in the early developmental stage and require empirical testing and further validation (Gao et al., 2019; Kanuri & Andrews, 2019; Kerr & Kelly, 2019), while longitudinal studies and a more extended data collection period also remain an area of interest for further investigation in all themes (McColl-Kennedy et al., 2015; Yumurtacı Hüseyinoğlu et al., 2017). There is also a need for researchers to test the relevance and validity of existing models and measurements in the new service environment (Huré et al.,

2017). Future research can examine the customer journey in other niche service environments, such as the sharing economy and subscription-based industries. More importantly, researchers should not restrict the exploration of the customer journey to the individual consumption process. They are encouraged to apply the concept to deepen the understanding of other marketing constructs and business contexts, such as the customer recovery journey or the social customer journey (Ryan Hamilton et al., 2020; Van Vaerenbergh et al., 2019). Moreover, researchers could innovatively combine more than one of the identified themes and theories from various disciplines in a study to enhance the integrative understanding about the customer journey.

The large volume of individual-level touchpoint data also offers opportunities and complexity for future research (Kannan & Li, 2017). Social media platforms and mobile applications serve as rich data sources for various inputs and concurrent experiences (Baxendale et al., 2015). However, it is imperative to develop a new data collection approach and data integration methods to track and organise ubiquitous data (Åkesson et al., 2014; Ponsignon et al., 2017). A next-generation data solution would enable researchers and practitioners to have the right tools to collect the right data, which in turn will minimise data inaccuracy and unnecessary spending (Barker, 2011). Furthermore, the current set of literature has often been reliant on completed journeys (De Keyser et al., 2015; Herhausen et al., 2019). Thus, future studies are encouraged to explore the possibility of using technological innovations to capture real-time data for better accuracy and deeper analysis (Becker & Jaakkola, 2020). Lastly, there is a need to develop new integrative scales that can temporally and efficiently measure all the dimensions of customer experience, not just cognitive but also attitudinal and behavioral aspects, across different touchpoints in all phases of the customer journey (Patti et al., 2020; Voorhees et al., 2017).

7. Conclusion

The customer journey has been gaining attention from both academia and practitioners over the past decade. The customer journey literature has been growing at a rapid rate, especially in the last three and a half years, when more than half of the retrieved literature was published. However, the literature has appeared as incoherent due to its diverse theoretical background. Therefore, this stream-based systematic review has attempted to aggregate and integrate the current body of knowledge by identifying the underlying themes of the field. The results have revealed five themes, namely customer experience, customer response, co-creation, channels and technological disruption, and summarised the knowledge of each topic in the context of the customer journey. The contribution of this review is threefold. Firstly, the review has clarified the underlying themes of the customer journey literature. Secondly, it has made recommendation for future study to advance the knowledge about the customer journey. Lastly, it has advanced the knowledge of the customer journey for academia and practitioners.

Nevertheless, the review is subjected to some limitations. It is important to recognise that the scope and perspective of the review have been shaped by the working definition of the customer journey that is adopted from the previous review on terminologies of the customer journey (Følstad & Kvale, 2018b). The definition has put an emphasis on the structure and component perspective of the customer journey. The review did not utilise customer experience as an additional search term to reduce noises in the search results. Such an inclusion would increase the volume by more than tenfold. However, the restricted keywords have narrowed the focus of the review and left out papers that potentially contribute to the multidimensional customer responses perspective of the customer journey. Secondly, due to the nature of the dendrogram, the results reflect the common themes and the current research trend of the retrieved literature set. The themes and their features may evolve as the customer journey literature grows. Therefore, the review could be replicated in the future to evaluate the development of the field.

Lastly, the review does not explicitly discuss the identified themes and sub-themes in relation to the three phases of the customer journey as the retrieved articles did not consistently cover the same or all stages. Future studies may contribute to the domain by focusing on a specific thematic area and scrutinising it in regard to the phases of the journey.

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Figure 1: The PRISMA diagram

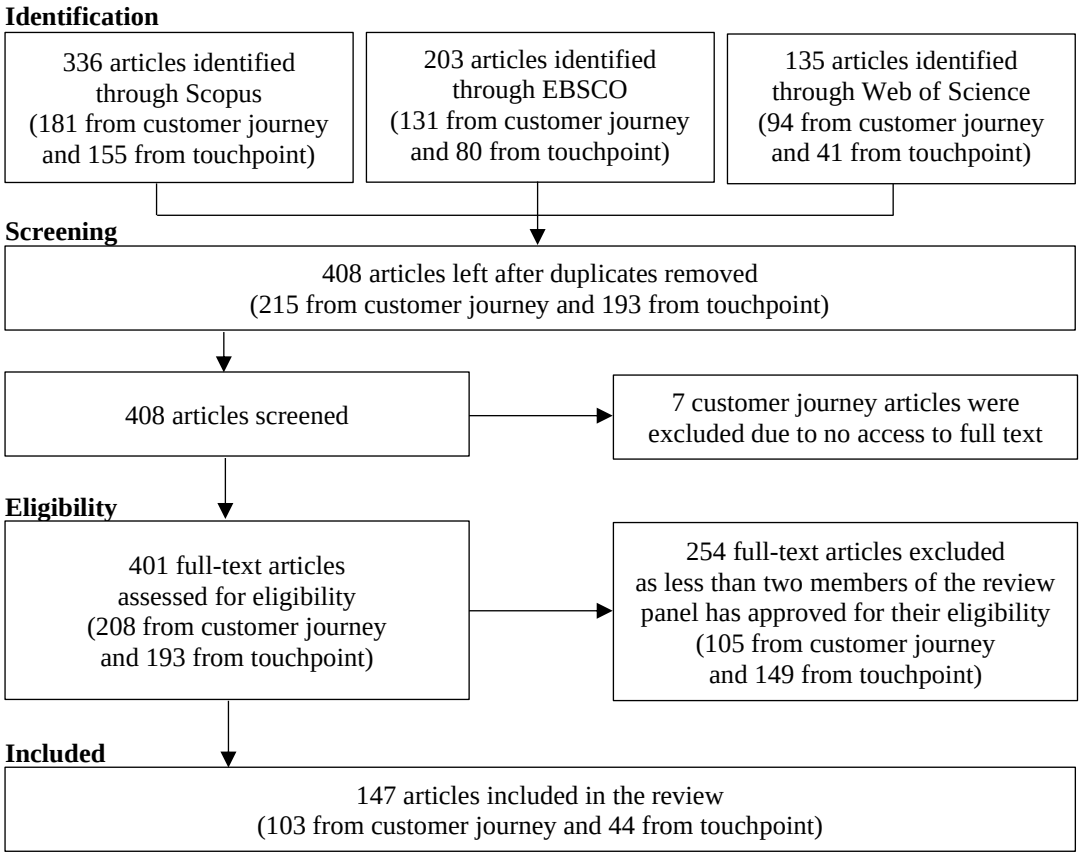


Table 1: Bibliographic sources of the customer journey articles

Journal	Before 2005	2006 - 2010	2011 - 2015	2016 - May 2020	Total
Journal of Services Marketing	0	0	2	7	9
Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services	0	0	0	9	9
Journal of Direct, Data and Digital Marketing Practice	0	3	5	0	8
Journal of Retailing	0	0	1	7	8
Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science	0	0	0	8	8
Journal of Business Research	0	0	0	7	7
Journal of Service Management	0	1	3	2	6
International Journal of Retail and Distribution Management	0	0	0	6	6
Journal of Service Research	0	1	1	3	5
Harvard Business Review	0	2	2	0	4
Business Horizons	0	1	1	2	4
International Journal of Research in Marketing	0	0	1	3	4
Journal of Service Theory and Practice	0	0	1	3	4
Business Process Management Journal	1	0	0	0	1
Canadian Journal of Administrative Sciences	1	0	0	0	1
Others	0	2	16	45	63
Total	2	10	33	102	147

Note: The listed journals have either published at least one article before 2005 or published more than three articles in total.

Table 2: The ten most cited articles of the customer journey literature

	Author(s)	Journal	Total citations
1	Lemon and Verhoef (2016)	Journal of Marketing	738
2	Meyer and Schwager (2007)	Harvard Business Review	544
3	Zomerdijk and Voss (2010)	Journal of Service Research	404
4	Kannan and Li (2017)	International Journal of Research in Marketing	187
5	Croteau and Li (2003)	Canadian Journal of Administrative Science	183
6	Tax et al. (2013)	Journal of Service Research	151
7	Li and Kannan (2014)	Journal of Marketing Research	134
8	Bolton et al. (2014)	Journal of Service Management	118
9	Voorhees et al. (2017)	Journal of Business Research	110
10	Breidbach et al. (2014)	Managing Service Quality	109

Note: Based on Scopus (8 October 2020)

Table 3: Theories used in the customer journey articles

Theory	Frequency
Game theory	3
Social practice theory	3
Relationship marketing theory	2
Uses and gratifications theory	2
Prospect theory	2
Utility theory	2
Experiential learning theory	2
Network theory	2
Information processing theory	2
Complexity theory	2
Justice theory	2
Adaption level theory	2
Cognitive dissonance theory	2
Construal level theory	2
Consumer culture theory	2
Diffusion of innovations theory	2
Role theory	2
Social exchange theory	2
Others	26
Total	64

Note: The listed theories have been applied more than once in the literature set and the total frequency exceeds the number of articles that explicitly state the theories because some studies applied multiple theories (e.g. Kerr and Kelly (2019), Rosenbaum et al. (2019) and Steward et al. (2019)).

Table 4: The five most frequently studied contexts in the customer journey articles

	Industry	Frequency		Country	Frequency
1	Tourism	18	1	United States	17
2	Financial services and insurance	16	2	United Kingdom	14
3	Electronics	15	3	Italy	10
4	Events and entertainment	15	4	Germany	8
5	Clothing and apparel	14	5	Sweden	6

Table 5: Method used in the customer journey articles

Method	Before 2005	2006 - 2010	2011 - 2015	2016 - May2020	Total
Conceptual paper	1	5	9	34	48
Survey	1	2	8	22	33
Interview	0	2	9	22	33
Secondary data	0	1	6	23	31
Focus group	0	0	1	11	12
Ethnography	0	0	2	7	9
Diaries	0	0	2	2	4
Real-time tracking	0	0	0	1	1
Total	2	10	37	122	171

Note: Totals exceed the number of retrieved articles because some studies use multiple methods (e.g. Aichner and Gruber (2017), Huré et al. (2017) and Sultan (2018)).

Table 6: Variables researched in the quantitative customer journey articles

Variables	Frequency
Independent variables	
Customer-related variables	
Channel choice	15
Touchpoint exposure	11
Customer satisfaction	5
Perceived value	4
Customer engagement	2
Customer emotional response	2
Customer experience	2
Other individual contexts (e.g. customer goal, purchase frequency and spending)	10
Company-related variables	
Channel strategy	6
Management capability	2
Type of company	1
Journey-related variables	
Touchpoint attributes	6
Journey structure	2
Touchpoint ownership	1
Dependent variables	
Customer-related variables	
Customer experience	5
Loyalty (repurchase and advocacy)	11
Purchase intention	5
Customer satisfaction	4
Customer cognitive and emotional responses	4
Impulsiveness	2
Perceived value	2
Others (e.g. channel choice, self-disclosure and willingness to donate)	7
Company-related variables	
Conversion rate	3
CRM performance	3
Retention rate	2
Others (e.g. clickthrough rate, reach and company value)	4
Journey-related variable	
Classification of touchpoints	1
Mediator variables	
Customer-related variables	
Customer attitudes	3
Customer experience	3
Relationship quality	2
Others (e.g. emotional response, loyalty intention and perceived value)	4
Company-related	
Business and channel strategy	3
Others (e.g. customer value and management capability)	2
Moderator variables	
Customer-related variables	
Psychographics	3
Purchase intensity	2
Sociodemographic	2
Others (e.g. brand involvement, channel exposure and perceived benefits)	7
Company-related variable	
Business strategy	2
Journey-related variables	
Channel ownership	1
Journey phase	1
Touchpoint interaction effect (carryover and spread over effect)	1

Note: The reported frequencies are based on empirical studies, excluding articles that do not include quantitative examination of bivariate or multivariate relationships (e.g. Becker and Jaakkola (2020), Faulds et al. (2018) and Halvorsrud et al. (2016))

Figure 2: Dendrogram of frequently occurring terms

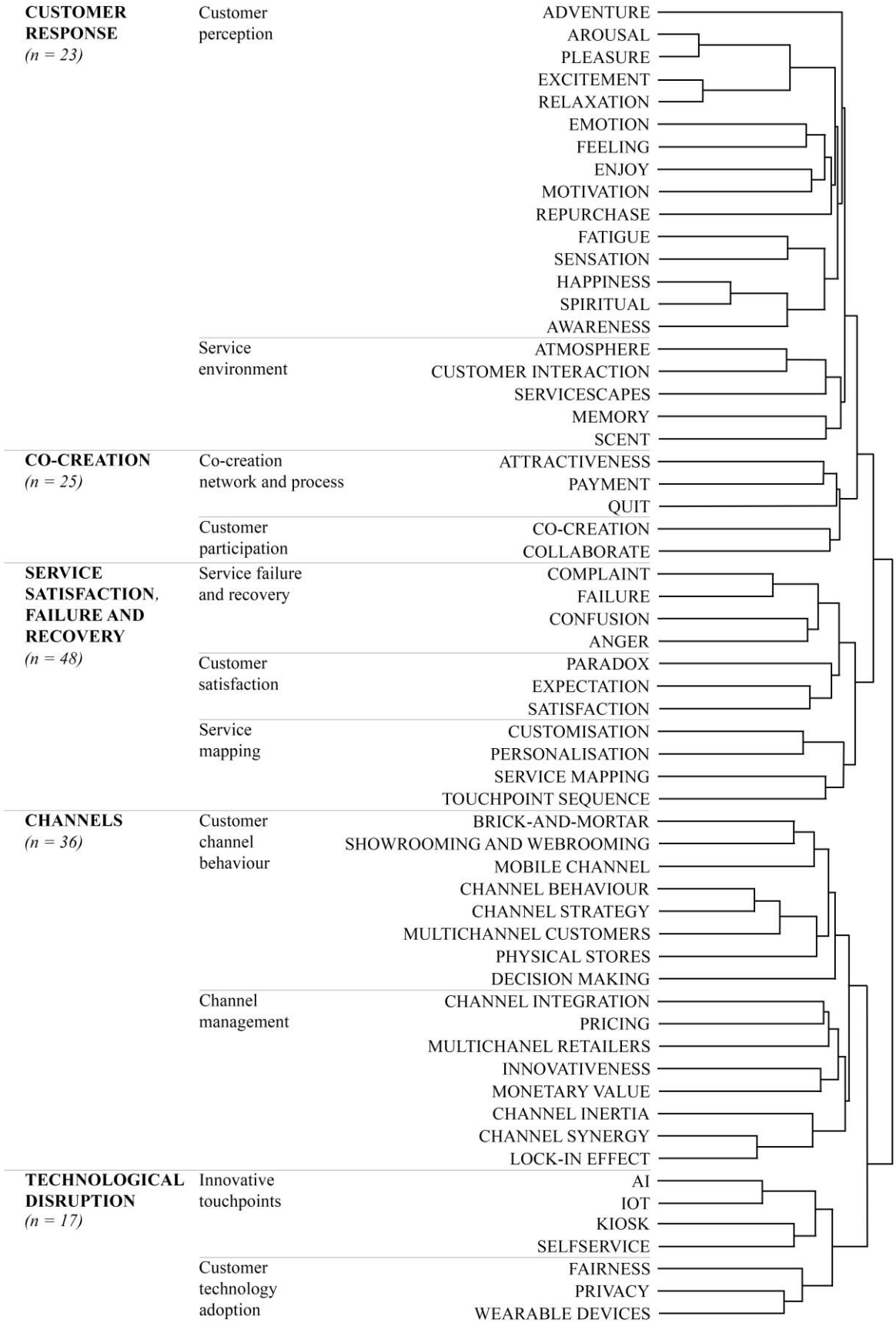


Table 7: Publication pattern of the customer journey literature

Theme	Before 2005	2006 - 2010	2011 - 2015	2016 - May2020	Total
Service satisfaction, failure and recovery	2	5	11	28	46
Channels	0	2	8	26	36
Customer response	0	2	6	15	23
Co-creation	0	1	7	17	23
Technological disruption	0	0	1	16	17

Figure 3: Heat map of research themes against phases of a customer journey

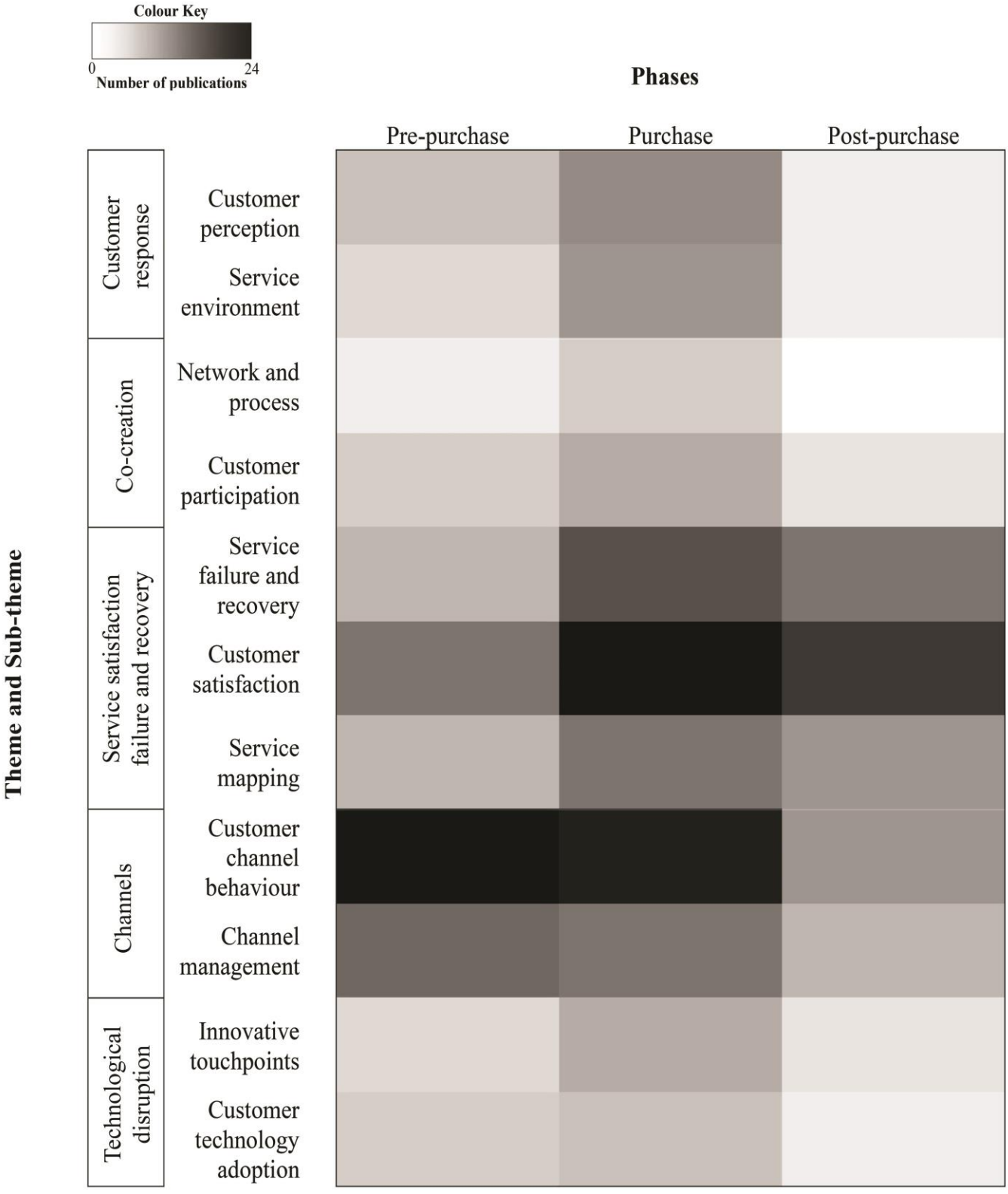


Table 8: Research agenda

Thematic area	Research questions
Service satisfaction, failure and recovery	
Customer satisfaction	• Which touchpoints and phases are the most critical determinants of customer satisfaction? • How customer expectations differ from phase to phase? What are the essential customer expectations that companies must fulfil at each phase to ensure a high level of customer satisfaction? • What constructs should be considered beside service quality for a more comprehensive and efficient measurement of customer satisfaction in the customer journey?
Service failure and recovery	• What kind of touchpoint interruption (e.g. unplanned touchpoints, missing touchpoints, touchpoint breakdown or an irregularity in touchpoint sequence) in the pre-purchase phase that cause a customer to drop the journey? • Are there early signs or critical negative incidents that companies should look out for to prevent a major service failure? • How does the stage of customer lifecycle moderate the consequences of a service failure and a service recovery journey? • What are critical touchpoints in the service recovery journey that help to overturn the negative customer experience?
Service mapping	• In what contexts the customer journey does not follow a linear and sequential pattern? What are the alternative patterns and structures of the customer journey? • What are the challenges and solutions for companies in mapping a customer journey? • What are factors that companies should consider when deciding their best practice for customer journey mapping?
Customer response	
Customer perception	• What are the critical attributes of a touchpoint that contribute to pleasure and comfortability of customers when undertaking a journey? • How customer emotions develop through different touchpoints and phases of a journey? What are their impacts on customer experience and loyalty intentions? • How do cognitive and emotional responses of the customer interact and jointly influence customer intentions and behaviours in the subsequence phases of the journey?
Service environment	• How do digital advances impact constitution of service attributes? How does the digital service environment affect customer perception in the customer journey? • How can companies align their service elements with the changing judgement strategies of the customers in different phases of the journey? • What are the results of outsourcing dissatisfying touchpoints on customer perception about locus of control? How does it impact on customer loyalty and evaluation on the company?

Co-creation	
Network and process	• What are different roles of a company in the sharing economy that it has limited control over the process? To what extent should the company intervene the customer journey? • How can innovative touchpoints and advanced technological tools be used to increase the efficiency and attractiveness of the co-creative activities and processes? • How can a company facilitate customers in the post-purchase phase to repurchase or cross buy other products and services? • How to map a customer journey beyond a dyadic interaction between a customer and a company to include touchpoints from third parties?
Customer participation	• Does the level of customer participation in each phase of the journey have the same impact on customer experience? What aspects of the customer co-creation behaviour have the highest influence on customer's evaluation? • How do the abundant choices of channels in an omnichannel retail environment affect customer's willingness to participate? Does more choices always give better outcomes for customers and companies?
Channels	
Customer channel behaviour	• How do customer channel behaviours evolve over the period of relationship with the company? • Are there other recognisable customer omnichannel behaviours, beside showrooming and webrooming, when extending the research scope beyond physical stores and websites and take all three phases of the journey into the consideration?
Channel management	• What are typologies of touchpoints in the omnichannel environment? • How to integrate innovative and traditional touchpoints to maximise performance of the customer journey? • How to track and measure contribution of each touchpoint in the customer journey on customer conversion and retention rate?
Technological disruption	
Innovative touchpoints	• How innovative touchpoints have disturbed and changed the structure of the customer journey? • What kind of relationship does customers develop with autonomous touchpoints? Do customers feel committed and loyal to autonomous touchpoints?
Customer technology adoption	• What regulations and measures a company can implement to reassure customers about their privacy? • Do customers perceive a trade-off between personalised service and privacy issue? • What are the contextual-level and individual-level factors that facilitate or impede customers to adopt innovative touchpoints?